

Chapter 38: When Familiar Becomes Fragile

Jenny started the day already tired.

Not physically.

Emotionally.

She hated that distinction was becoming easier to recognize.

Austin was already there when she arrived.

Same seat.

Same posture.

Same calm.

But Jenny didn't feel the same.

Something in her had shifted overnight, quietly, like a crack forming under glass that still looked whole.

"Morning," she said.

Austin looked up.

"Morning."

A pause.

"You didn't sleep well," he added.

Jenny stopped mid-step.

"...Excuse me?"

"I can see it."

She sighed sharply.

"You can't see everything."

"I can see you," he corrected.

That made her pause.

Unfair.

Too direct.

Too simple.

The restaurant filled faster than usual.

Jenny moved through it mechanically.

Orders.

Smiles.

Heat.

Noise.

But her awareness kept drifting back to him.

Not because he was doing anything unusual.

Because he wasn't.

And that stability felt unfamiliar now.

At one point, she passed table seven and stopped without realizing it.

Austin was watching her.

Of course he was.

Jenny frowned.

"You're doing that thing again."

"What thing?"

"Looking at me like you're trying to read my thoughts."

"I'm not trying," he said calmly.

"I'm observing your behavior."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"There it is again. Observing."

A faint pause.

Then—

"It helps me understand when something changes."

Jenny tilted her head slightly.

"Something always changes?"

"Yes," he said.

"You just don't always say it out loud."

That landed quietly.

Too accurately.

Later, during a lull, Jenny finally spoke again.

"You've been... different since Victoria came."

Austin looked up immediately.

"I haven't changed."

Jenny shook her head.

"Yes, you have."

A pause.

Then he said calmly,

"I became more direct."

"That's not what I mean."

Austin studied her for a moment.

Then—

"You mean emotionally."

Jenny didn't answer.

Because yes.

That was exactly what she meant.

Austin leaned slightly forward.

"Victoria didn't change me," he said.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"She was your past."

"Yes."

"So she affects you."

A pause.

Then quietly—

"She affected who I used to be."

Jenny frowned.

"And who are you now?"

Austin didn't hesitate.

"Someone who stays."

That word again.

Stay.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"You say that like it's simple."

"It's not simple," he said.

"It's just decided."

Jenny looked at him.

"...Decided by who?"

Austin met her gaze.

"By me."

Silence.

That answer should have been reassuring.

But it wasn't.

Because it left no room for negotiation.

No uncertainty.

No distance.

Only intention.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

But this time, her voice came quieter.

"What if I don't want things to be decided already?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

That pause mattered.

Then he said gently,

"Then tell me what part you don't want decided."

Jenny hesitated.

That was the problem.

She didn't know.

Not fully.

The shift came slowly after that.

Not a fight.

Not a rupture.

Just a subtle tension.

Like two people standing too close to something fragile without realizing it.

Jenny moved faster.

Austin stayed still.

Jenny deflected more.

Austin noticed more.

At closing time, Jenny wiped the counter longer than necessary.

Avoidance had become automatic now.

Austin stood near the exit.

Waiting, as always.

But Jenny didn't immediately walk over.

Instead, she spoke from where she was.

"You're too certain," she said.

Austin looked at her.

"I'm not certain about everything."

"That's not what it feels like."

A pause.

Then—

"What does it feel like?"

Jenny hesitated.

Then quietly—

"Like I'm already part of something I didn't agree to fully yet."

Silence.

That was the first time she said it out loud.

Austin didn't interrupt.

Didn't defend.

Didn't retreat.

He just stood there.

Then said calmly,

"You didn't disagree either."

That landed.

Harder than she expected.

Jenny looked at him.

"...That's not fair."

"I'm not trying to be fair," he said.

"I'm trying to be honest."

A pause.

Then softer—

"And I don't want to lose you because I waited too long to be clear."

Silence again.

This one heavier.

Jenny swallowed.

"I need time," she said quietly.

Austin nodded once.

"I know."

But he didn't leave immediately.

Instead, he added,

"I can give you time."

A pause.

Then—

"But I won't disappear during it."

Jenny looked at him.

"...That sounds like the same thing you've been doing."

Austin shook his head.

"No."

A beat.

"Now you know I'm here."

Silence.

Jenny didn't respond.

Because he was right.

And that changed everything.

When he finally left, it didn't feel like distance.

It felt like continuity.

And Jenny stood alone behind the counter realizing something she wasn't ready to fully admit yet:

It wasn't his presence that unsettled her anymore.

It was the fact that she could no longer imagine him becoming absent again.